war that portended disastrous consequences. As a signal of its intent, Pakistan's prime minister Shehbaz Sharif had reportedly summoned the country's National Command Authority, of which he is the chair and the three service chiefs its members. It is the supreme body that decides on deployment of Pakistan's nuclear weapons. Modi remained unmoved and told Vance firmly that India's riposte would be "far more forceful, stronger and devastating". He reinforced the point in his address to the nation, making it clear that "India will not tolerate any nuclear blackmail, and strike decisively" and that, in doing so, it "would not discriminate between the government sponsoring terrorism and the masterminds of terrorism". A day after Pakistan launched drone and missile attacks on 36 different locations on India's western border, India unleashed "hellfire", as an official puts it, launching precision strikes on eight key bases, and damaging runways and communication facilities in Pakistan. The strikes included the one at Nur Khan, located between Islamabad, Pakistan's capital, and Rawalpindi, headquarters of the Pakistan army.

Why Pakistan Cried Uncle

With India demonstrating that it could strike Pakistan at will, including government and army nerve centres, and its navy poised to blockade the Karachi port, crippling it economically, Pakistan's leadership, as a senior Indian official says, "cried Uncle"—meaning they rang the US for help. He believes that the devastating air strikes convinced Pakistan that the war would only go downhill for them. Both Sharif and Munir reportedly spoke to US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, asking the US to intervene and get India to stand down. They apparently claimed that if an all-out war did break out, Pakistan would be forced to use all its options, which, they hinted, may even include bringing nuclear weapons to the table. Husain Haqqani, a former Pakistan ambassador to the US and currently a senior fellow at the Hudson Institute, says, "Sometimes, the threat itself is superior to action. India lost the narrative on terrorism and it became more about destroying Pakistan. That turned into a David vs Goliath story. One thing that is missing in the international media coverage of the war was terrorism."

Rubio is said to have spoken to Jaishankar who told him that Pakistan was to blame for moving up the escalation ladder. In its counterstrike to the Pahalgam attack, India had struck terrorist hideouts and avoided military targets. Lt Gen. Rajiv Ghai, the director general of military operations (DGMO) in the army, had even called up his Pakistan counterpart Maj. Gen. Kashif Abdullah 15 minutes after the first wave of strikes and told him that India had no intention of launching further strikes. But Abdullah apparently told him to go to hell and said that Pakistan would retaliate. In his conversation with Rubio, therefore, Jaishankar reportedly said that if Pakistan wanted a truce, then it should use the DGMO hotline to do so. On



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INDIA AGREED TO THE TRUCE AS IT HAD ALREADY MET ITS KEY OBJECTIVE—SETTING A NEW PUNITIVE DETERRENCE POLICY WITH GRADED ESCALATION AGAINST PAKISTAN'S TERROR EXPORT

May 10, Abdullah called Ghai and told him Pakistan wanted a ceasefire. Ghai consulted his seniors and, by 3.35 pm, informed Abdullah that India had agreed. And that's how the 88-hour war came to an end even if it was amidst a host of claims and contradictions. As a senior Indian official remarks, "Pakistan wanted a ceasefire not because you spoke good English but because something hard hits its bases from the sky."

The reason India took the exit ramp Pakistan asked for was because it had never wanted an all-out war. Its objectives were to communicate that 'enough is enough', and take punitive action against terrorist organisations that have launched attacks on India in the past 25 years, while warning both Pakistan and its terror cohorts of stronger action if they continued with their nefarious agenda. However, to India's dismay, American president Donald Trump posted about the ceasefire on social media even before India and Pakistan had announced it, claiming full credit for orchestrating it. To make matters worse, Rubio put up another post on X, claiming both India and Pakistan had also agreed "to start talks on a broad set of issues at a neutral site". Trump's trumpeting continued too, as he proceeded to boast about preventing "a nuclear conflict" in the subcontinent in one social media post,